

■ By Nirmala Ravindran

Milking cows could at best be described as a bovine activity. Or so you thought. Not so for a schoolteacher and dairy farm owner from Murulya in Karnataka, who has silently effected a transformation in this mechanical activity. His milking machine has empowered small farmers for over six years now, but

his tryst science began when he was still in school. "I was always experimenting with new things and won prizes in school for innovations," he says proudly. Now a school teacher, Gowda ended up working on an idea that would revolutionise the lives of thousands of farmers. "Even though everyone in my family is a teacher, we cultivate our own land. Every farmer has cows, and milking them is a big problem. We too had problems with skilled labour and hygiene. Imported milking machines cost Rs 93,000 and are beyond the reach of simple farmers, which is why I set out to create an effective but low-cost alternative," says Gowda. He realised the desperation of

farmers when he was forced to sell his prized cow for lack of labour in 1999, because he twisted a nerve while milking it. "It was one of the saddest things in our family. It was our favourite cow and we had to sell it because we didn't have anyone to milk her. I realised that there must be many people like me and decided to do something about it," he says.

The project that he embarked on was difficult, with no end in sight. "I had to take a year off from teaching in 1999 with no salary, and since I didn't want the children to suffer, I offered to pay for a substitute in my absence," he adds. Gowda's trial period lasted nearly three years but his fina-

white BEAUTY

✱ Raghava Gowda, 54

Project A milking machine, Milk Master

Can-do Icon No one actually. Everything I've done in life has been based on my own need. If that can help others, so be it.

There are
200
million cows
in India.



Photographs by SANJAY RAMACHANDRAN